3 a Work with a partner and plan your own narrative poem about taking a dragon for a walk.

- First, decide where the dragon will go and who you might meet there.
- Convey your ideas about the reactions you might receive from other people in these places.
- Copy and complete this planning table.

Use a thesaurus to find synonyms. Add new words to your *Spelling log*.

Where?	Who?	Reaction?	Synonyms?
railway station	passengers	stare	gawp and glare

b Now, decide who the narrator of your poem will be. You could choose another person in your class, or even your teacher.

- Explain how this person's register is the same or different from your own register.
- Write one verse for each place you visit and try to capture the narrator's voice. Use comments in brackets to show what the narrator is thinking. For example:

I took my dragon to the railway station
to see the trains breathing smoke like him;
the people they did gawp and glare
(my mum always says, 'It's rude to stare')
so we left the platform and wandered on.

semi-colon
comma
inverted commas

Proofread your writing carefully for punctuation and spelling. When writing poems, it's easy to miss punctuation because the lines are laid out differently.

Go further

1. In small groups, share your poems so each person can practise and read aloud a poem they did not write. Use the punctuation to help you to find the correct tone of voice.
2. Evaluate the poems the group has written. Which stories, rhymes and voices do you like best? Which poem has the most or the least formal register? Explain your opinions.

Challenge yourself!

1. Work with a partner and reread the poems you have written. Reflect on what the dragon's viewpoint might be. For each verse, suggest how the dragon might describe what is happening. Listen, reflect on and respond to each other's suggestions.
2. Write a poem to retell the events from the dragon's viewpoint. Try to give the dragon a voice that is clearly different from the one you used originally. In pairs, evaluate each other's poems. Comment on whether the dragon's viewpoint has or hasn't been achieved and how.

Exploring a range of features in one poem

Do you remember?

Idiomatic language is the figurative language we commonly use when speaking. It can include ways of referring to people. For example:

simile → *She slept like a log.* → She slept deeply or heavily.

metaphor → *He's a real live wire.* → He's full of energy.

Learn

Poets may use a wide range of features in one poem to create memorable stories and imagery. These poems may appear quite complicated at first, but if you read them first to find out explicit information (who, what, where, when and why) and then explore figurative language (such as simile, metaphor and personification) and devices such as rhyme, alliteration, consonance and assonance, you will be able to understand and enjoy them.

Did you know?

Libby Houston is a rock climber, a scientist and a poet. She even discovered a new species of plant that is named after her: Houston's Whitebeam.

Get started!

1 With a partner, read aloud this section of a poem about a different kind of dragon, a dragonfly nymph (baby form). Comment on how the poet makes the nymph seem like a monster. Which is your favourite part of the poem so far? Explain your opinion.

Personal response

Have you ever seen a dragonfly? Which flying insects can you name? What are your personal responses to these insects? Do you think of them as tiny monsters like the dragonfly in this poem? Explain your opinions.

Select at least five powerful words from the poem and add them to your *Spelling log*. In small groups, compare your word choices and explain why you have chosen them.

The Dragonfly

There was once a terrible monster
lived in a pond, deep under the water.

Brown as mud he was, in the mud he hid,
among **murk** of reed-roots, sodden twigs,
with his long hungry belly,
six legs for creeping,
eyes like headlights
awake or sleeping;
but he was not big.

A **tiddler** came to sneer and jeer
and **flaunt** his flashing tail –
Ugly old stick-in-the-mud
couldn't catch a snail!
I'm not scared –
when, like a shot,
two **pincers nab** him, and he's got!

For the monster's jaw hides a clawed stalk
like the arm of a robot, a dinner fork,
that's tucked away cunningly till the last minute –
shoots out – and back with a victim in it!

Days, weeks, months, two years and beyond,
fear of the monster **beset** the pond;
he lurked, grabbed, grappled, gobbled and grew,
ambushing always somewhere new –

Who saw him last? Does anyone know?
Don't go near the mud! But I must go!
Keep well away from the rushes! But how?
Has anyone seen my brother? Not for a week now –
he's been eaten
for certain!

By Libby Houston

2 Explore the poem with a partner and take turns (A and B) to identify the answers to these questions:
   a Where in the pond does the monster live? (A)
   b What colour is he? (B)
   c What size is he? (A)
   d Who teased the monster? (B)
   e What happened to this character? (A)
   f How long does the monster live in the pond? (B)
   g What does it do to the other creatures? (A)

You will be asked to write a summary of the poem later. Decide when and how it would be useful to take notes.

3 a The poet uses idiomatic language to describe the monster. Find the phrases that mean:
   slow | boring
   b What idiomatic phrases do you use for these words?
   slow, boring | fast, interesting

4 a Summarise the story of the poem in no more than 70 words. Share your summary with a partner. What are the similarities and differences between your summaries? Did either of you make inferences or did you only include explicit information?
   b Discuss with a partner and then write a paragraph about what you think will happen next in the story of the poem.

Glossary
murk: darkness
tiddler: small fish
flaunt: show off, boast
pincers: like claws
nab: catch
beset: filled

Go further

1 a The poet describes the monster's behaviour like this: **lurked**, **grabbed**, **grappled**, **gobbled** and **grew**. Read this line using a different expression for each verb. Why has the poet put so many verbs on one line?

b The poet has chosen each word of her poem very carefully. Look again at the verbs in the poem. Find at least one synonym for each verb. Discuss with a partner which word best fits the poem. Write sentences to explain your reasons. For example:

Verb from the poem	Synonym	Which word is best and why?
lived in a pond	lurked	We think **lurked** is better because it sounds more dangerous.
in the mud he hid	concealed himself	
a tiddler came to sneer	mock or tease	
pincers nab him	trap	

2 Comment on the similes used to describe the monster. Explain what each simile suggests to you.

eyes like headlights

like a shot, two pincers nab him

a clawed stalk like the arm of a robot

Evaluate your answers with another pair. Add more detail to explain your choices.

3 a Work with a partner and explain why the poet has presented some of the writing in italics. Read these sections aloud with expression to show how the characters are feeling.

b In small groups, read each sentence of the poem aloud. Find and copy examples of:

- rhyme
- alliteration
- consonance
- assonance
- onomatopoeia.

Assign roles, each person should be responsible for recording examples for one of the language features; then, share your results.

c Next, comment on the effects of the figurative language on the poem. Take turns to be the first person to offer an answer. Listen to one another, reflect and then ask questions or add your own opinions.

Challenge yourself!

1 Read aloud the sections of the poem that are in italics. Who do you think is speaking here? How do they feel about the dragonfly nymph?

2 Imagine that the nymph can see the fish and other insects. Write a paragraph from its point of view to show what it thinks about them.

3 Can you rewrite your paragraph as a verse for a poem?

Creating a poem with a range of features

Do you remember?

Verbs often describe actions:

*The dragonfly **emerged** from its nymph's body and **stretched** its new wings.*

Adverbs perform many different functions, including describing verbs:

*The dragonfly **instantly** flew away.*

Learn

Poets rarely make only one draft of a poem. They will generate ideas, find words, compose lines and then improve them by playing with language until they are happy with what they have created.

- They will create imagery, for example, using figurative language such as **personification**, **similes**, **metaphors** and carefully-chosen **vocabulary**.
- They will use **alliteration**, **consonance**, **assonance** and **rhyme** to convey mood.
- They will use **punctuation** and **line breaks** to show how the poem should be read.

Get started!

1 a Read the next part of Libby Houston's poem aloud to find out what happened to the dragonfly nymph.

b Summarise this part of the poem in 40, 50 or 60 words.

c What have you learned about the life cycle of a dragonfly from this poem? Show your partner how you would explain the life cycle to a younger child. Choose a register that would help the child to understand. Then, show how you would explain the life cycle to a scientist. How did you change your register?

Personal response

In groups, discuss the predictions you made in the last theme with what actually happens in the poem. Ask others what they predicted and then describe the similarities to, and differences from, your own prediction.

And then, one day, it was June, they all saw him.
He was coming slowly up out of the mud,
they stopped swimming. No one dared
approach, attack. They kept back.

Up a tall reed they saw him climbing
higher and higher, until
he broke the surface, climbing still.

There he stopped, in the wind and the setting sun.
We're safe at last! they cried. *He's gone!*

What became of the monster, was he ill, was he sad?
Was nobody sorry? Had he crept off to die? Was he mad?